globally by the Telugus and Kannadigas, while the erstwhile dominant Bhojpuris lagged behind in relative terms. The march of the Bengalis within and outside India has also kept up pace, and the spread of the language was supplemented by outmigration from Bangladesh.[63]

If there is one striking cultural practice that unites Indians across all these identities and separates India from the places they usually migrate to, it is the use of water in toilets as opposed to tissue paper abroad. Indians' love for water is closely matched with their love for steam generated by the pressure cooker, a wonderful gift of humankind celebrating both rice and noise, amplified many times over in silent honk-less neighbourhoods abroad. It is no wonder then that a mug and a pressure cooker are important objects packed in the luggage of a first-time visitor or settler in new lands. Indian assimilation in host societies abroad not only involves learning the native language and celebrating their sporting teams but also, inevitably, wearing fewer saris and converting household practices towards using tissue paper and noiseless rice steamers, the last practice being the toughest to adapt to.

Assimilation was difficult for the first-generation migrant, despite Nehruvian advocacy for four decades after Independence. After the abolition of the indentured system, Indian nationalists and then the Indian government followed a hands-off policy on overseas Indians, turning away from the crises faced by Indians in East Africa in the 1970s for instance. 'When in Rome, do as the Romans do' was the unspoken official mantra. This began to change in the 1980s because the Chinese were successfully wooing their diaspora to invest in China, setting a template and opportunity for the Indian government to consider. Since the 1970s, concerns over the treatment of migrant workers in West Asia had already forced the governments of major sending states to set up services for emigrant welfare. During the Gulf War of 1990–91, the Indian government promptly evacuated 1,00,000 Indians stranded in Kuwait. In 2001, with the publication of an official report on the Indian diaspora, the engagement with the Indian diaspora began to fundamentally change. 'Diaspora' was no longer a phenomenon to be studied by sociologists, it would henceforth be